



### **The Viet Minh advance**

On March 13, 1954, the Viet Minh opened the fighting at Dien Bien Phu by capturing a key French hilltop outpost, codenamed Beatrice. Viet Minh infantry overwhelmed the French defenses.

### **Besieged on all sides**

Desperate to avoid disaster, the French government sought US assistance. A plan was devised for a fleet of 60 US B-29 bombers to attack Viet Minh positions. The use of atom bombs was even discussed. However, President Dwight D. Eisenhower ruled against intervention. The only Americans to take part were civilians flying transport aircraft.

The besieged garrison continued its heroic resistance, unable to evacuate its wounded and increasingly short of munitions. Fresh reinforcements parachuted in, but antiaircraft fire rendered air operations perilous, as did the onset of the monsoon. In a classic siege technique, the Viet Minh dug trench systems toward the French perimeter, until close enough to overcome the defenses by infantry assault. Giap launched the final attack on May 1. There was no surrender. On May 7, the shattered remains of the French fortified camp fell to the Viet Minh in hand-to-hand combat.

In eight weeks of fighting, about 2,000 soldiers on the French side had been killed. The battle had been even costlier for the Viet Minh, with an estimated 8,000 killed and twice that number wounded. But Giap had inflicted such a humiliating defeat upon France that any continuation of its colonial rule in Indochina was unthinkable.

“[I] feel the **end is approaching** but we will **fight to the finish.**”

COLONEL CHRISTIAN DE CASTRIES, MESSAGE FROM DIEN BIEN PHU, MAY 7, 1954